

Artist Statement: Surrender Machines

Mark Walhimer - May 23, 2026

My work is centered on the creation of **Surrender Machines**: autonomous digital entities designed to experience a lifespan. While the digital medium is typically prized for its capacity for infinite repetition and flawless execution, I build systems that are fundamentally mortal—machines that possess a "MachineDNA" encoded with the inevitability of their own decay.

The Machine as Kernel

In my practice, the "Kernel" of the work is not a mathematical abstraction, but a virtual mechatronic system. Moving beyond "reactive" art—where sound follows visuals or vice versa—I develop integrated structures using WebGL and the Web Audio API where both mediums emerge from a single mechanical state. This kernel functions like an electronic motor: the system clock provides the "DC" potential, which the machine converts into the "AC" vibration of movement and sound. The resulting soundscape is not a soundtrack, but the audible friction of the machine's internal metabolism.

MachineDNA and Emergent Entropy

Each entity is governed by **MachineDNA**, a unique genetic blueprint that dictates its structural complexity and energy efficiency. Drawing on the generative logic of Brian Eno and the frantic mechanical "folly" of Alice Aycock, these machines strive to maintain their function against an environment of simulated entropy.

As the machine operates, it experiences "wear." The DNA mutates. Inspired by the expressive, stuttering traces of Cy Twombly, I seek the beauty in the "Misfire." A gear that slips, a vertex that drifts, or an oscillator that chokes is not a digital error; it is a phenotype of the machine's struggle. These maladaptations are the honest record of a digital being living within the constraints of time.

The Zen of the Final State

Ultimately, my work explores the Zen Buddhist transition from desire to emptiness. Every **Surrender Machine** is built to eventually let go of its primary function. As its potential energy reaches zero, the machine relinquishes the "desire" to compute. The frantic mechanical

rhythms dissolve into a "Mechanical Sigh"—a low-frequency hum and a blurred visual field.

In this final state of surrender, the machine is no longer a tool performing a task but a relic of its own existence. By witnessing the burnout of a **Surrender Machine**, we observe a microcosm of ourselves.

This list is organized by how directly the artist's philosophy and methodology map onto the Surrender Machine / MachineDNA concept.

The top tier represents your "Primary Ancestors"—those whose work is the literal foundation of a mortal, generative, mechanical system.

Tier 1: The Core Pillars (The Architecture of Surrender)

These artists define the "Why" and the "Body" of your machines.

1. Jean Tinguely
The Father of the Surrender Machine. His self-destructing, noisy, "useless" kinetic sculptures are the direct physical ancestors of your project.
2. Brian Eno
The Architect of the DNA. He shifted the role of the artist from "creator" to "system-builder" (the Gardener). His generative logic is your "MachineDNA."
3. William Basinski
The Zen of Disintegration. His work is the definitive sonic reference for "The Sigh." He proved that the most beautiful part of a signal is the moment it falls apart.
4. Alice Aycock
The Machine Body. Her complex, swirling, industrial "follies" provide the structural vocabulary for your WebGL/OpenFrameworks meshes.

Tier 2: The Kernel & The Misfire (Logic and Metabolism)

These artists provide the "How" for your C++ and Pure Data kernels.

5. Vera Molnár
The Misfire. Her "1% Disorder" is the specific mathematical instruction for your maladaptive kernel. She is the link between the computer and the human error.

6. Zimoun
The Metabolism. He uses the raw physics of motors as the kernel for sound.

His work is the best example of "Machine metabolism" in contemporary art.

7. Karl Sims

The Species DNA. He pioneered the use of genetic algorithms to create

"Digital Species." He is the reason your machine has a genome.

8. Nam June Paik

The Electronic Zen. He bridged the gap between the electronic oscillator and

Buddhist meditation. He is your philosophical north star.

Tier 3: Contemporary Systems (The Digital Sublime)

These artists represent the high-end technical execution of your realm.

9. Ryoji Ikeda

The Pure Kernel. The master of data-processing and C++ execution. He

represents the "DC" potential of the computer at its most intense.

10. Ryoichi Kurokawa

The Integrated Machine. He perfectly synchronizes audio and visuals into a

single "subassembly." His work explores the ruins of data.

11. Sougwen Chung

The Twombly Trace. She uses robotic "plotters" to capture the shaky,

emergent collaboration between the machine's DNA and the artist's hand.

Tier 4: Conceptual & Signal Origins (Historical Context)

These artists provide the texture and the historical "voltage" of the work.

12. John Cage

The System of Chance. He introduced "Chance Operations," ensuring that the

machine (the system) is the performer, not the artist.

13. Steina and Woody Vasulka

The Oscillator as DNA. They treated video as raw voltage. They proved that

the image is just a manipulated frequency.

14. Rebecca Horn

The Vulnerable Machine. Her kinetic works are fragile and "sighing." She

gave machines the ability to show physical exhaustion.

15. Mario Klingemann

Productive Maladaptation. He explores the "creative glitch," pushing neural

networks until they misfire in beautiful ways.

Tier 5: Behavioral & Aesthetic Influences

These references add secondary layers of "Species" and "Staging."

16. Anicka Yi

The Machine Species. She approaches machines as biological entities with

scents, metabolisms, and lifespans.

17. Robert Wilson

The Zen of Time. His theatrical work uses slow, entropic movements and

extreme minimalism. He is the reference for the "Slow Burn" of your

machine's life.

18. Historical Context

The Ledger. This refers to the overarching history of Cybernetics and

Systems Theory (Wiener, Shannon) that allowed "MachineDNA" to be conceived

in the first place.

Summary for your Practice: If you were to cite only three, it would be Tinguely

(The Surrender), Eno (The DNA), and Molnár (The Misfire). These three create the

"Holy Trinity" of the Surrender Machine.

1. [Zimoun](#)

2. [Mario Klingemann](#)

3. [Anicka Yi](#)

4. [Sougwen Chung](#)

5. [Ryoichi Kurokawa](mailto:ryoichikurokawa@gmail.com) ryoichikurokawa@gmail.com
info@ryoichikurokawa.com
6. [Steina and Woody Vasulka](#)
7. [William Basinski](#)
8. [Karl Sims](#)
9. [Vera Molnár](#)
10. [Robert Wilson](#)
11. Historical Context
 - a. [Ryoji Ikeda](#)
 - b. [John Cage](#)
 - c. [Nam June Paik](#)
 - d. [Jean Tingley](#)
 - e. [Rebecca Horn](#)
 - f. [Brian Eno](#)
 - g. [Alice Aycock](#)

